

ART & CULTURE



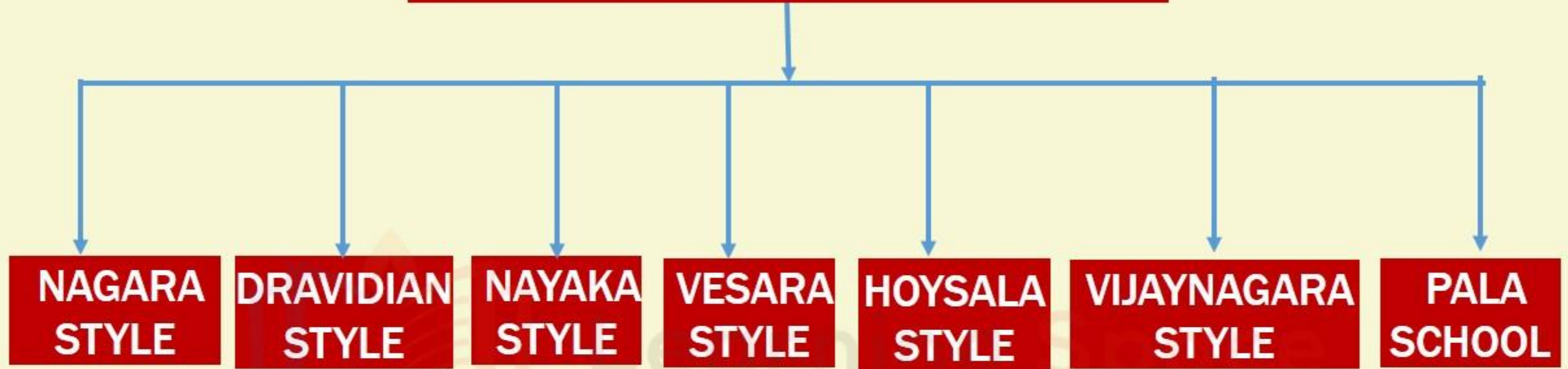
INDIAN ARCHITECTURE

MODULE - 19

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

- NAGARA
- DRAVIDIAN

STYLE OF TEMPLE ARCHITECTURES



Under the patronage of the local rulers, different styles of architecture developed in the different regions of India as given above.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

THE NAGARA OR NORTH INDIAN TEMPLE STYLE



Nagara style temple

- 1 The style of temple architecture that became popular in northern India is known as Nagara.
- 2 In North India it is common for an entire temple to be built on a stone platform with steps leading up to it.
- 3 Further, unlike in South India, it does not usually have elaborate boundary walls or gateways.
- 4 The garbhagriha is always located directly under the tallest tower.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

THE NAGARA OR NORTH INDIAN TEMPLE STYLE



Latina or rekha-prasada

5 There are 3 main subdivisions of nagara temples depending on the shape of the shikhara.

1. Latina or rekha-prasad
2. Phamsana
3. Valabhi

6 The most common name for the simple shikhara which is square at the base and whose walls curve or slope inward to a point on top is called the latina or the rekha-prasada type of shikara.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

THE NAGARA OR NORTH INDIAN TEMPLE STYLE



Phamsana

- 7** The second major type of architectural form in the Nagara order is the **phamsana**.
- 8** Phamsana buildings tend to be **broader and shorter than latina ones**.
- 9** Their roofs are composed of **several slabs that gently rise to a single point** over the centre of the building, unlike the latina ones which look like sharply rising tall towers.
- 10** Phamsana roofs do not curve inward, instead they slope upwards on a straight incline.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

THE NAGARA OR NORTH INDIAN TEMPLE STYLE

- 11** Later on, the latina buildings grew complex, and instead of appearing like a single tall tower, the temple began to support many smaller towers, which were clustered together like rising mountain-peaks with the tallest one being in the centre, and this was the one which was always above the garbhagriha.



TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

THE NAGARA OR NORTH INDIAN TEMPLE STYLE



Valabhi

12 The third main sub-type of the nagara building is what is generally called the **Valabhi type**.

13 These are **rectangular buildings with a roof that rises into a vaulted chamber**.

14 The **edge of this vaulted chamber is rounded**, like the bamboo or wooden wagons that would have been drawn by bullocks in ancient times. They are usually called '**wagon vaulted buildings**'.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

1

NAGARA TEMPLE STYLE

a

ODISHA SCHOOL

In different parts of the Kalinga empire, a distinct style of temple architecture developed. Some of its features are:



Rekhadeuls of Odisha school

1

The exterior walls were lavishly decorated with intricate carvings, but interior walls were plain.

2

There was no use of pillars in the porch. Iron girders were used instead to support the roof.

3

The Shikharas in the Odisha school were known as **rekhaddeuls**. They were almost vertical roofs which suddenly curved inwards sharply.

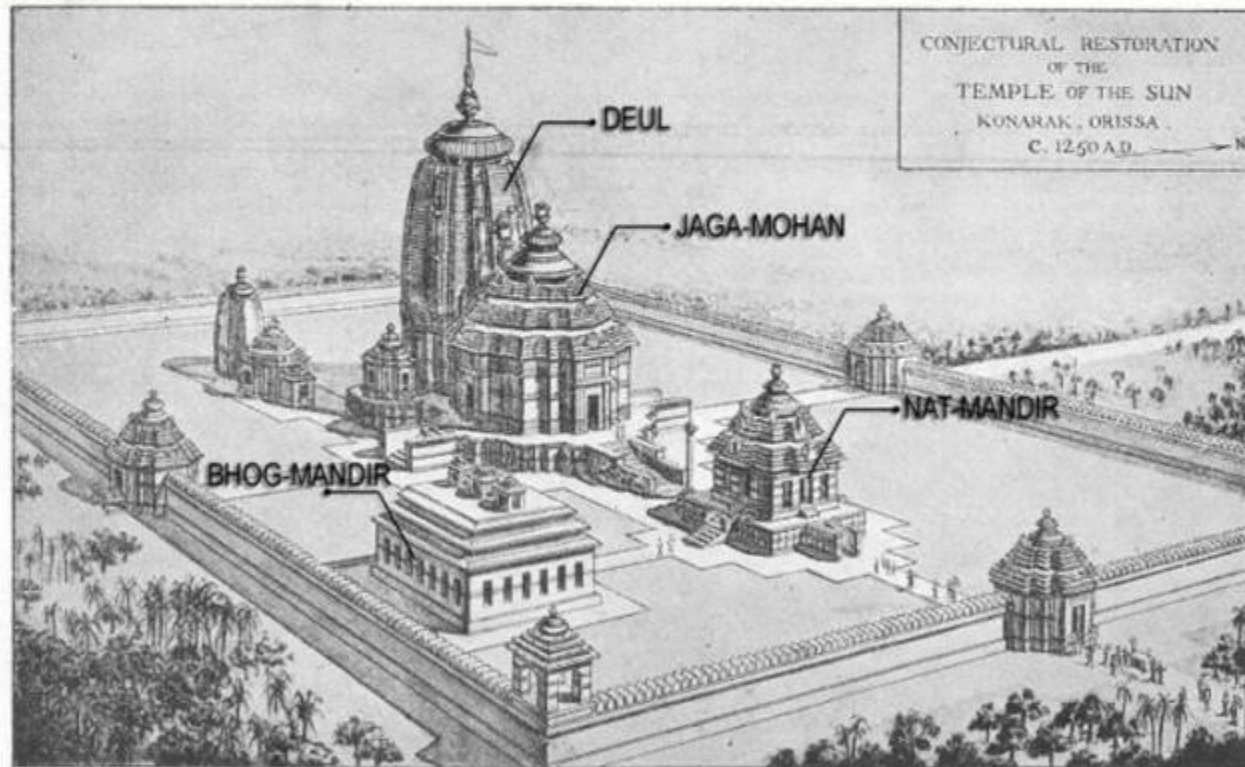
TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

1

NAGARA TEMPLE STYLE

a

ODISHA SCHOOL



4

The **mandaps** were known as **jagmohanas** in this region

5

The ground plan of the main temple was square.

6

Temples were surrounded by a boundary wall as in Dravidian style of temple architecture.

7

Example: Sun Temple at Konark (also known as Black Pagoda), Jagannath temple at Puri, Lingaraj temple at Bhubaneswar, etc.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

1

NAGARA TEMPLE STYLE

a

ODISHA SCHOOL

KONARK SUN TEMPLE



Sun Temple, Konark

- 1 At Konark, on the shores of the Bay of Bengal, lie the majestic ruins of the Surya or Sun temple built in stone around 1240.
- 2 Its shikhara was a colossal creation said to have reached 70m, which, proving too heavy for its site, fell in the nineteenth century.
- 3 The vast complex is within a quadrilateral precinct of which the jagamohana or the dance-pavillion (mandapa) has survived.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

1

NAGARA TEMPLE STYLE

a

ODISHA SCHOOL

KONARK SUN TEMPLE



4

The Sun temple is set on a high base, its walls covered in extensive, detailed ornamental carving.

5

These include twelve pairs of enormous wheels sculpted with spokes and hubs, representing the chariot wheels of the Sun god who, in mythology, rides a chariot driven by eight horses, sculpted here at the entrance staircase.

6

The whole temple thus comes to resemble a colossal processional chariot.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

1

NAGARA TEMPLE STYLE

a

ODISHA SCHOOL

KONARK SUN TEMPLE



Surya god in Konark temple

7

On the southern wall is a massive sculpture of Surya carved out of green stone.

8

It is said that there were three such images, each carved out of a different stone placed on the three temple walls, each facing different directions.

9

The fourth wall had the doorway into the temple from where the actual rays of the sun would enter the garbhagriha.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

1

NAGARA TEMPLE STYLE

b

KHAJURAHO SCHOOL

In the central part of India, the Chandel rulers developed a distinct style of temple making of their own- known as **Khajuraho school** or **Chandel school**. The features of the temples here include:



Lakshmana Temple, Khajuraho

1

In contrast to the earliest known Panchayatan-style Deogarh temple of the same Central Indian region, if we study the temples of Khajuraho made in the tenth century, i.e., about four hundred years after the temple at Deogarh, we can see how dramatically the shape and style of the nagara temple architecture had developed.

2

The Lakshmana temple dedicated to Vishnu is the grandest temple of Khajuraho, built in 954 by the Chandela king, Dhanga.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

1

NAGARA TEMPLE STYLE

b

KHAJURAHO SCHOOL

- 3 It is placed on a high platform accessed by stairs. The temple had 3 chambers—**mandapa**, **garbhagriha**, and **ardha-mandapa**. Some temples had a **vestibular entrance** to the garbhagriha known as **antarala**. The temples were generally north or east facing.



Figure: Kandariya Mahadeva temple, Khajuraho

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

1

NAGARA TEMPLE STYLE

b

KHAJURAHO SCHOOL



4

There are four smaller temples in the corners, and all the towers or shikharas rise high, upward in a curved pyramidal fashion, emphasising the temple's vertical thrust ending in a horizontal fluted disc called an amalaka topped with a kalash or vase.

5

The crowning elements: amalaka and kalash, are to be found on all nagara temples of this period.

6

The temple also has projecting balconies and verandahs, thus very different from Deogarh.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

1

NAGARA TEMPLE STYLE

b

KHAJURAHO SCHOOL



7

Khajuraho's temples are also known for their extensive erotic sculptures drawing inspiration from Vatsyayana's Kamasutra; the erotic expression is given equal importance in human experience as spiritual pursuit, and it is seen as part of a larger cosmic whole.

8

Many Hindu temples therefore feature Mithun (embracing couple) sculptures, considered auspicious.

9

Usually, they are placed at the entrance of the temple or on an exterior wall or they may also be placed on the walls between the mandapa and the main shrine.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

1

NAGARA TEMPLE STYLE

b

KHAJURAHO SCHOOL



Kandariya Mahadeva temple, Khajuraho

10 Khajuraho's sculptures are **highly stylised** with typical features: they are in almost full relief, cut away from the surrounding stone, with sharp noses, prominent chins, long slanting eyes and eyebrows.

11 The other notable example at Khajuraho is **Kandariya Mahadeva temple** dedicated to Lord Shiva.

12 There are many temples at Khajuraho, most of them devoted to Hindu gods

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

1

NAGARA TEMPLE STYLE

b

KHAJURAHO SCHOOL

- 13** There are some Jain temples as well as a Chausanth Yogini temple, which is of interest.



- 14** Predating the tenth century, this is a temple of small, square shrines of roughly-hewn granite blocks, each dedicated to goddesses associated with the rise of Tantric worship.

- 15** Several such temples were dedicated to the cult of the yoginis across Madhya Pradesh, Odisha and even as far south as Tamil Nadu.

- 16** They were built between the seventh and tenth centuries, but few have survived.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

1

NAGARA TEMPLE STYLE

c

SOLANKI SCHOOL



Jain temples in Mount Abu

1

The stones used to build the temples in the north-western parts of India like Gujarat and Rajasthan varies in colour and type.

2

While sandstone is the commonest, a grey to black basalt can be seen in some of the tenth to twelfth century temple sculptures.

3

The most exuberant and famed is the manipulatable soft white marble which is also seen in some of the 10th to 12th century Jain temples in Mount Abu.

4

While the patronage of these is debated, the date is established on the basis of the style.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

1

NAGARA TEMPLE STYLE

c

SOLANKI SCHOOL

SUN TEMPLE, MODHERA



Sun Temple, Modhera

1

The Sun temple at Modhera dates back to early eleventh century and was built by Raja Bhimdev I of the Solanki Dynasty in 1026.

2

The Solankis were a branch of the later Chalukyas.

3

The garbhagriha is connected with the mandapa both internally as well as externally.

4

The porticos have decorative arched gateways known as torans.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

1

NAGARA TEMPLE STYLE

c

SOLANKI SCHOOL

SUN TEMPLE, MODHERA



Suryakhund in Modhera

5

A unique feature of this school is the presence of step-tank known as suryakhund in the proximity of the temple.

6

Proximity of sacred architecture to a water body such as a tank, a river or a pond has been noticed right from the earliest times. By the early eleventh century they had become a part of many temples.

7

This hundred-square-metre rectangular pond is perhaps the grandest temple tank in India. A hundred and eight miniature shrines are carved in between the steps inside the tank.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

1

NAGARA TEMPLE STYLE

c

SOLANKI SCHOOL

SUN TEMPLE, MODHERA



Modhera Sun temple, Gujarat

8

A huge **ornamental arch-torana** leads one to the sabha mandapa (the assembly hall) **which is open on all sides**, as was the fashion of the times in western and central Indian temples.

9

The **influence of the woodcarving tradition of Gujarat** is evident in the lavish carving and sculpture work.

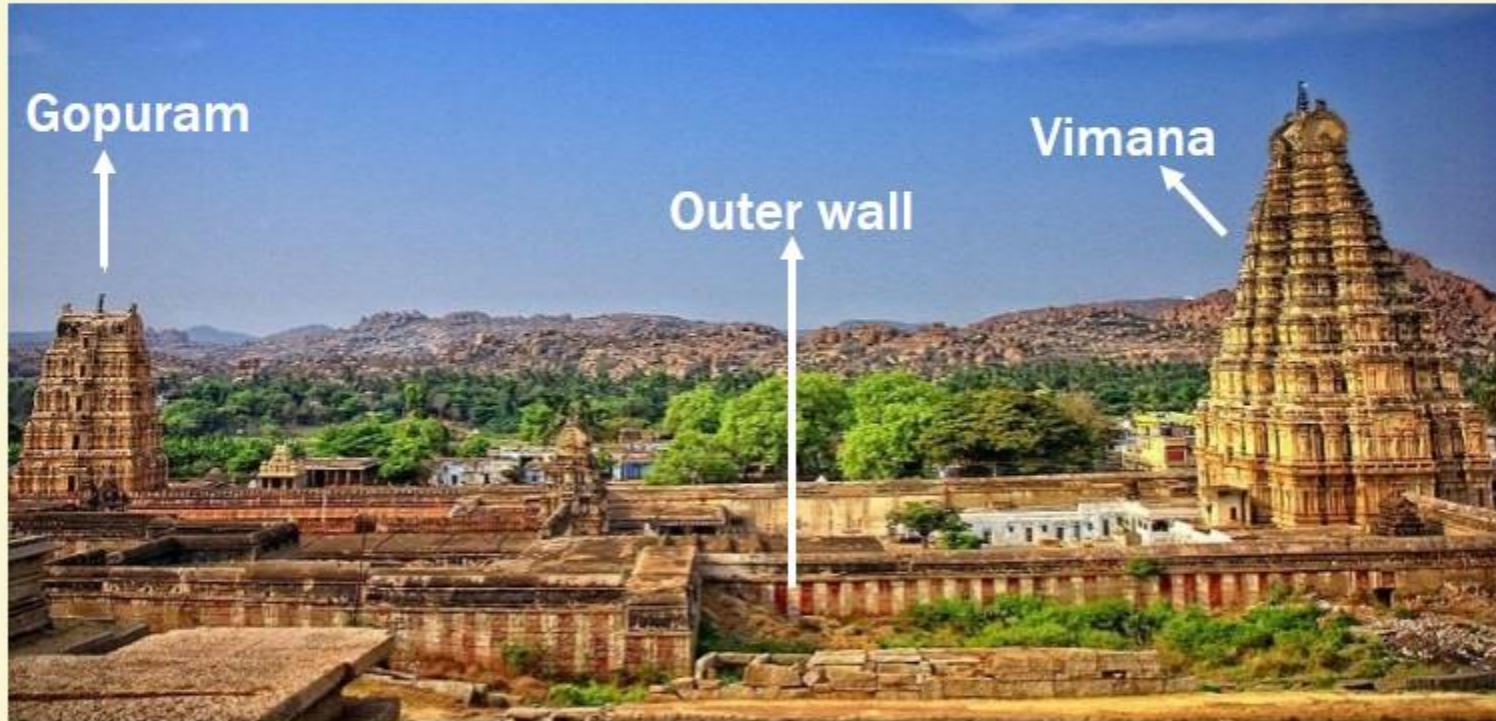
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However, the **walls of the central small shrine are devoid of carving** and are left plain as the temple faces the east and, every year, at the time of the equinoxes, the sun shines directly into this central shrine.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

2

SOUTH INDIAN STYLE



Virupaksha Temple, Hampi

- 1 Unlike the nagara temple, the dravida temple is enclosed within a compound wall.
- 2 The front wall has an entrance gateway in its centre, which is known as a **gopuram**.
- 3 The shape of the main temple tower known as **vimana** in Tamil Nadu is like a **stepped pyramid** that rises up geometrically rather than the curving shikhara of North India.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

2

SOUTH INDIAN STYLE



**Temple tank in Meenakshi Amman
Temple, Madurai**

4 Whereas at the entrance to the North Indian temple's garbhagriha, it would be usual to find images such as **mithunas** and the river goddesses, Ganga and Yamuna, in the south you will generally find **sculptures of fierce dvarapalas** or the door-keepers guarding the temple.

5 It is common to find a **large water reservoir**, or a **temple tank**, enclosed within the complex.

6 **Subsidiary shrines** are either incorporated within the main temple tower, or located as distinct, separate small shrines beside the main temple.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

2

SOUTH INDIAN STYLE



In Nagara style, tallest shikara houses the main deity usually.

7 The North Indian idea of multiple shikharas rising together as a cluster was not popular in South India.

8 At some of the most sacred temples in South India, the main temple in which the garbhagriha is situated has, in fact, one of the smallest towers.

9 This is because it is usually the oldest part of the temple.

10 With the passage of time, the population and size of the town associated with that temple would have increased, and it would have become necessary to make a new boundary wall around the temple.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

2

SOUTH INDIAN STYLE



**Srirangam temple with
saptaprakarams**

11 This would have been taller than the last one, and its gopurams would have been even loftier.

12 So, for instance, the Srirangam temple in Tiruchirapally has as many as seven 'concentric' rectangular enclosure walls, each with gopurams.

13 The outermost is the newest, while the tower right in the centre housing the garbhagriha is the oldest.

14 Temples thus started becoming the focus of urban architecture.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

2

SOUTH INDIAN STYLE



Brihadeeswarar temple, Thanjavur

- 15** Kanchipuram, Thanjavur or Tanjore, Madurai and Kumbakonam are the most famous temple towns of Tamil Nadu, where, during the eighth to twelfth centuries, the role of the temple was not limited to religious matters alone.
- 16** Temples became rich administrative centres, controlling vast areas of land.
- 17** Just as there are many subdivisions of the main types of nagara temples, there are subdivisions also of dravida temples.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

2

SOUTH INDIAN STYLE

- 18** These are basically of five different shapes:
1. **Kuta or caturasra**- square;
 2. **Shala or ayatasra**- rectangular;
 3. **gaja-prishta** or elephant backed, or also called **vrittayata**- elliptical, deriving their names from wagon vaulted shapes of apsidal chaityas with a horse-shoe shaped entrance facade usually called a nasi;
 4. **Vritta**- circular;
 5. **Ashtasra**- octagonal

- 19** Generally speaking, the plan of the temple and the shape of the vimana were conditioned by the iconographic nature of the consecrated deity, so it was appropriate to build specific types of temples for specific types of icons.

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